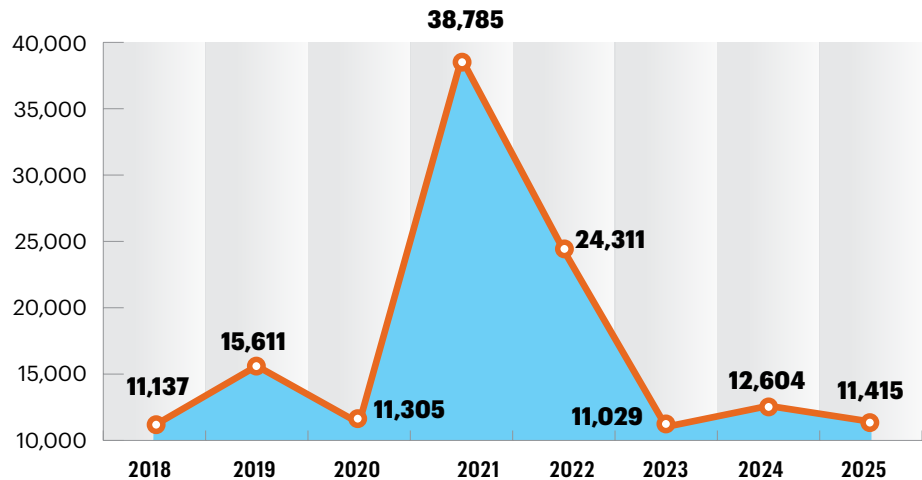


FUNDS RAISED BY INDIAN TECH START-UPS

● Start-ups got a funding boost post Covid

NOTE FIGURES IN \$ MN
SOURCE TRACXN



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to do for transport what Flipkart had done for retail. The ambition, however, extended beyond ride-hailing. As Ola Electric became his next act, Aggarwal repeatedly argued that the goal was never just chasing valuations. “The focus is on value creation and not valuation... We are in the business of building for a sustainable future,” he told *BT*, framing the company’s larger ambition as helping build India into a global EV hub. The shift also reflects how this generation of founders increasingly sees itself not merely as building consumer apps, but creating globally competitive manufacturing and technology businesses.

Ritesh Agarwal, barely out of his teens, founded OYO in 2013 to standardise India’s fragmented budget-hotel market, later restructuring parts of it under the Prism umbrella, one of the fastest founder-to-billionaire timelines in Indian history.

Both Ola and OYO disrupted traditional transportation and hospitality markets by digitising fragmented inventory, aggressive price discounting, and implementing mobile-first booking systems.

Not every disruption was a consumer app. Alakh Pandey and Prateek Maheshwari built Physics Wallah out of a YouTube channel, betting correctly that cheap data had created a market of small-town students who owned a phone but couldn’t afford traditional coaching. Their low-cost video model turned the two teachers into billionaires by undercutting an entire industry.

Despite that scale, Pandey says the company’s operating philosophy has barely changed. “Physics Wallah may look like it has grown tremendously, but inside our way of working remains the same,” he had said earlier.

With BrowserStack, Ritesh Arora and Nakul Aggarwal took a different route. Building a cross-browser testing tool sold to developers globally is a proof that this generation wasn’t only digitising Indian problems but exporting infrastructure to the world.

Ruchi Kalra co-founded Ofbusiness, applying the same digital-first playbook to something as unglamorous as B2B raw-material procurement.

MANY NAMES, ONE UNDERLYING STORY

Each of these founders inherited infrastructure rather than having to build it. Cheap smartphones to reach users. Cheap data to keep them online. UPI to move money between them without friction. On top of that sat global venture capital, patient enough to fund years of losses for a shot at scale, and a cultural confidence that hadn’t existed a generation earlier.

India’s rich list still tilts heavily towards inherited wealth, business houses now on their second or third generation of leadership, growing what was handed to them rather than building from zero. Both paths produce billionaires. But only one of them had to invent its own market before it could conquer it.

The structural shift is real. Where Ambani needed 60 years and Premji needed 55, this generation needed a connected population, a payment rail that worked, and investors willing to bet on the gap between an idea and its scale. The clock has been reset, and it’s ticking a lot faster now. **BT**

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